Install both parts

Controller keyboard + optional free voice typing

For speech, use the Windows installer. CurseForge installs the in-game addon only; it cannot install or launch the companion.

1. Close WoW and download Setup

Download PadChat-Setup.exe from the official Preview 14 release. If you download the complete ZIP, choose Extract All first. You do not need Python, ChatGPT, an API key or a paid speech account.

2. Select the Forever folder

Choose the client folder containing Wow.exe, normally World of Warcraft_forever_. Select the client folder, not Interface/AddOns. Setup checks the game version. Version-checked older Forever WowB.exe clients remain supported.

3. Keep voice and automatic startup enabled

Leave Install voice typing and Start with Windows enabled, then install. On update, existing microphone, PTT and speech preferences are retained. If Windows asks for game-folder permission, use the same Windows account.

4. Choose your microphone

Select your headset microphone in the companion window, save, and close that window. The models are bundled and speech is processed locally. Start WoW and enable PadChat in the AddOns list.

Set up and speak

Use keyboard, mouse or controller

Open Guided setup

Click PadChat beside the minimap, then Help > Guided setup. The controller can open the PadChat keyboard with touchpad click or a configured opening button. F9 is optional.

Choose your controls

Under Voice, enable voice, choose your microphone and select Bind push-to-talk. Press the key or supported mouse button you want. New keyboard users prefer F10 or another unused key shown in Options; existing F8/custom bindings are kept. Controllers use Share/Create/Back or the saved button and modifier.

Save, reload, then test safely

Save the settings and reload when safe. In Help, run the microphone/PTT test; it records for the test but sends nothing to chat. Close any Windows microphone/binding dialog before trying PTT in game.

Tap to choose, hold to talk

Tap PTT to cycle available channels. Hold it and wait for green READY - SPEAK NOW. The meter responds to the microphone. Say one message, then release to send, or to review if you selected review-first mode. Check the destination shown in the overlay.

Find the other options

Controls: opening bindings and Reload UI. Voice: PTT, microphone and send mode. Appearance: overlay size, position and meter. Help: tests, restart and explicit failed-message recovery. D-pad moves between buttons; X/A activates.

Startup and recovery

No ChatGPT required to keep voice running

When Windows and WoW start

The small startup launcher waits for your selected Forever client, then starts the installed companion. It does not use your microphone while waiting. It closes the speech helper after the game exits and starts it on the next game launch.

If the companion exits unexpectedly

The launcher retries with a bounded delay. Unfinished dictation is discarded and never replayed automatically. Wait for readiness, release PTT fully, and start a fresh message. This does not fix every possible Windows, device or permission problem.

If you deliberately exit voice

Choosing Exit PadChat voice in the tray also stops automatic recovery for that Windows session. Open PadChat Voice from Windows Start to resume. If you disabled startup in Task Manager > Startup apps, enable it there or start PadChat manually.

If you see PC-VOICE-BRIDGE

Close chat/search and binding dialogs and keep WoW selected. After an addon-only update, close WoW and run the matching current Setup with voice enabled. It replaces old managed startup/menu shortcuts. Avoid launching old companion copies. Re-running Setup repairs missing installed files without deleting preferences.

Technical state: %LOCALAPPDATA%\PadChat\launcher-status.json. If it says another-companion-running, exit the older companion from its tray menu and open the current Start-menu entry. For help, use GitHub issues; share the release and error code, not private chat text.

Preview status: tested with automated and isolated Windows process checks against Forever 1.60.1.70888 / Interface 16001. A real reboot and clean second-PC test of this launcher are still outstanding.